

D Abhishek

Dr. Suresh P.

Research Methodology

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The Absence of Subaltern Voices of Colonial Violence in the Mainstream

Literary Canon: The Eram Massacre in Odisha

ABSTRACT

The Eram Massacre of September 28, 1942, stands as one of the most harrowing, yet oddly ignored, chapters of the Indian independence movement. It's often called *Raktatirtha*, or "The Blood Pilgrimage." Even though the death toll of 29 individuals actually surpassed the initial casualties at Jallianwala Bagh, the event has been pushed to the very edges of the national and global literary canon. This paper digs into the structural reasons behind that silence. To do it, I've looked through the lens of Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's landmark essay, "Can the Subaltern Speak?" alongside the historical records meticulously gathered in Dr. Jagannath Patnaik's *Raktatirtha Eram*.

The core argument here is that shutting Eram out of mainstream discourse isn't an accident; it's a definitive act of "epistemic violence" (Spivak 76). Spivak explains that the subaltern—people cut off from social mobility and political representation—are essentially robbed of a voice. Their history ends up being written by elite proxies who just can't translate the subaltern's unique consciousness. Look at Eram: the people involved were mostly illiterate peasants, fishermen, and marginalized women like Pari Bewa (Patnaik 42). They used local symbols, like the blowing of conch shells, and they were smart about exploiting the region's "natural fortress" geography (Patnaik 12). But because these people didn't have access to the

"scene of writing," their story was either twisted into a crime by colonial archives or drowned out by the urban, English-language history favored by the nationalist elite.

By blending Patnaik's local historical recovery with Spivak's theory, this study looks at the two sides of representation: *Vertretung* (acting as a political proxy) and *Darstellung* (creating a descriptive portrait). Ultimately, Eram's "silence" doesn't mean these people lacked agency. It means the mainstream canon has failed to build a way to actually listen for the subaltern trace. Bringing Eram into the literary fold isn't just about sticking a forgotten date in a textbook. It's about challenging a "heliocentric" historical bias that prizes the elite over the provincial (Spivak 94). If we're going to recover the voices of the Eram martyrs, we need a radical re-reading of colonial violence—one that respects the fine-grained textures of power and the sacrifice of those living on the "other side" of the international division of labor.

INTRODUCTION

The Eram Massacre of September 28, 1942, is easily one of the most harrowing, yet strangely overlooked, moments in the history of India's fight for independence. When we look at the history of colonial resistance, events like the 1919 Jallianwala Bagh massacre stand as central pillars of our national consciousness—etched into the literary canon as the definitive symbols of imperial cruelty. But Eram, a remote village in Odisha's Bhadrak district, saw a tragedy of comparable horror that's been mostly treated as a regional footnote. On that one afternoon, British police opened fire on a peaceful crowd at Melana Padhia, leaving 29 dead and 56 injured (Patnaik 3). In terms of sheer fatalities at a single location during the Quit India Movement, Eram was the bloodiest encounter in the country. Locally, it's known as *Raktatirtha*—the "Blood Pilgrimage."

It's difficult to equate such an enormous death toll with the paradox of silence that currently surrounds the event. Although the story remains within local Odia oral history and in local pamphlets, the tale goes unrecorded in both Indian and international literature. This paper digs into the structural reasons for that silence. I'm interested in why an event this big never made the jump from a provincial memory to a national narrative. To figure that out, I've looked at the tragedy through the lens of Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's landmark essay, "Can the Subaltern Speak?" alongside the detailed historical records compiled by Dr. Jagannath Patnaik in *Raktatirtha Eram*.

The central argument here is that Eram's exclusion from mainstream discourse isn't an accident; it's a textbook case of what Spivak calls "epistemic violence" (Spivak 82). I contend that the massacre was erased from the dominant literary canon because the people involved—mostly illiterate peasants and marginalized groups—lived on the "other side" of the international division of labor. Their resistance happened in a vernacular and a socio-political register that elite, English-educated historians either couldn't or wouldn't translate. Ultimately, the silence around Eram shows how colonial and post-colonial knowledge structures work together, making sure the subaltern's "Blood Pilgrimage" never gets fully transcribed into the language or educational frameworks used by the global elite.

SPIVAK AND THE MECHANICS OF SILENCING

To really get why the Eram Massacre is still just a "shadow" in Indian history, you have to look at the framework Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak lays out in *Can the Subaltern Speak?* Her work isn't just about pointing out what's missing from the history books; it's an autopsy of how silencing actually happens. She defines the "subaltern" as groups so far removed from social mobility and political power that they don't have a platform to speak with any authority

(Spivak 78). When you apply this to Eram, you see a massive divide between the "elite" nationalist leaders and the people actually on the ground. The elite were urban, English-educated intellectuals who had the standing to negotiate with the British. The victims at Eram, though? They were mostly illiterate peasants, fishermen, and marginalized women. Take Pari Bewa—a widow who died from British bullets. She's the face of the subaltern condition. For her and her neighbors, this wasn't some abstract pursuit of a high-level "Swaraj." It was a local, desperate fight for their land and their dignity. Since they were outside the "international division of labor" and the loop of elite education, their resistance looked nothing like the organized, well-dominated protests happening in the big cities.

This gap leads straight to what Spivak calls the core problem of representation. She breaks it into two ideas: *Vertretung* (representing someone in a political or legal sense—like "speaking for" them) and *Darstellung* (representation as a "re-presentation" or a creative portrait). The Eram victims were definitely represented in terms of *Vertretung*. The nationalist leadership used their deaths as political leverage to push for independence. But the *Darstellung*—the actual portrayal of their inner lives, their specific motives, and their local goals—remained almost impossible to translate (Spivak 70). When an elite historian tries to speak "for" the subaltern, they often end up silencing them by projecting their own middle-class values onto the subject. Because the Eram victims were geographically isolated and couldn't read or write, they couldn't author their own "scene of writing." Their true intentions weren't captured in the journals of the day; instead, they were filtered through the language of their "representatives," leaving their actual voices lost in translation.

This whole failure is made worse by "epistemic violence"—the systematic scrubbing of any way of knowing that isn't Western or elite. For Eram, this happened in two waves. First came

the colonial censorship. If you look at online archives of British intelligence reports from 1942, you'll see a deliberate effort to paint the Eram gathering as a mob of "rioters" or "looters" to justify the shooting (National Archives of India). Those colonial records then became the go-to sources for later historians. However, once the country gained its independence, a new era of gatekeeping arrived in India's universities. "Great men" were the heroes in the conventional narratives, and urban themes had primacy because those were stories that could be fitted into a nice English-language tale of national history. Eram is largely known through Odia folklore or pamphlets such as Dr. Patnaik's *Raktatirtha Eram*. That gatekeeping made sure Eram stayed as "subjugated knowledge." It didn't fit the intellectual structures the post-colonial elite preferred, so the subaltern's trace wasn't just missed—it was strategically wiped out.

THE ANATOMY OF VIOLENCE AT MELANA PADHIA

Reconstructing the tragedy at Melana Padhia requires looking past the dry, clinical prose of colonial police logs. You must lean instead into the visceral historical recovery work of Dr. Jagannath Patnaik. The afternoon of September 28, 1942, was not an occasion for war in Eram. No, it was a place of calm. Some 5,000 men, the majority of whom were unarmed citizens that hailed from nearby villages, had gathered at this place to discuss the Quit India Movement (Patnaik 22). That shifted instantly when DSP Kunjabihari Mohanty arrived. His brutal efficiency would later earn him a local infamy as the "Dyer of Odisha." Just like General Dyer at Jallianwala Bagh, Mohanty used the geography of the site against the people. With the field boxed in by the Gamoi River and thick brush, there was only one narrow way out. Without a single warning or an order to disperse, Mohanty simply commanded his men to open fire. In minutes, the "natural fortress" of Eram became a death trap.

In the middle of this carnage, Pari Bewa stands out. She is the epitome of what the subaltern is all about. Although she had been widowed before joining the revolution and belonged to a poor family, she wasn't part of that revolution by virtue of any high status (Patnaik 45). The minute gunfire started, she did not flee away. She stood her ground and was struck down, becoming the massacre's only female martyr. This exclusion from the mainstream canon is precisely what Spivak refers to as the "double silencing" of the subaltern. In terms of being an Indian, she is automatically excluded from the realms of high history. However, by virtue of being a woman, she is rendered even more voiceless. Spivak famously points out that "if the subaltern cannot speak, the subaltern as female is even more deeply in shadow" (Spivak 83). The sacrifice of Pari Bewa is a double shadow—a shadow that is rendered invisible by the generic narrative of sacrifice of nationalism.

The chasm between the two versions of the past is made explicit by placing beside each other the oath that the peasants had sworn to and what had been recorded by the colonial authorities. "Mori paribu, pache dari paribu nahi": "We will die, but we will not fear" (Patnaik 28). This statement did not come as a result of mob hysteria, but was an ethical choice for *Satyagraha*. Yet, British reports tried their best to criminalize that agency. Official archives painted those 5,000 souls as a "lawless assembly" bent on looting and violence—a lie they needed to justify using lethal force (National Archives of India). This was the ultimate act of epistemic violence. The state used its "scene of writing" to rewrite a massacre as an act of self-defense. When you contrast Patnaik's recovery of that subaltern vow with those criminalizing reports, it's clear the "truth" of Eram was sacrificed long before the event was ever left out of the history books.

ANALYSIS: WHY THE CANON EXCLUDES ERAM

To figure out why the Eram Massacre is still a ghost in our national narrative, we've got to look at the linguistic walls guarding the Indian literary canon. This tragedy didn't just happen in a remote village; it stayed there, locked away in the Odia language. While the "mainstream" history of the freedom struggle was being debated in English—the language of the colonial state and the post-colonial academy alike—Eram's memory lived on through folk songs, oral traditions, and local pamphlets like Dr. Patnaik's *Raktatirtha Eram*. In the world of high academia, English is the gatekeeper. Because the subalterns of Basudevpur lacked the "cultural capital" to translate their trauma into a global *lingua franca*, their experience was easily brushed off as "folk history" or "regional interest" ("Eram: The Second Jallianwala Bagh"). It never reached the status of "national importance." This linguistic barrier is a tool of exclusion. It ensures the "scene of writing" remains a playground for the bilingual elite, effectively silencing anyone who can only testify in their mother tongue.

That exclusion is made worse by a systemic bias that prizes urban, organized resistance over rural, spontaneous uprisings. Jallianwala Bagh doesn't just dominate the canon because of the scale of the horror; it's centered because it happened in a major city with direct ties to the Congress party leadership. It fits a neat, linear story of national awakening. On the other hand, peasant-led massacres like Eram are often viewed through a patronizing lens—dismissed as "primitive" or "pre-political" outbursts. When the subaltern acts without the urban elite watching over them, their struggle gets pushed to the periphery. By labeling Eram as mere "regional history," the mainstream canon commits a second act of violence: it suggests that blood spilled in a remote Odia field is somehow less central to India's story than blood spilled in a Punjabi city.

Ultimately, Eram's disappearance from our textbooks is a perfect illustration of Spivak's warnings about the "vanishing" of the subaltern trace. She argues that the subaltern is obliterated the moment they're forced to fit the narrative of the "Subject of the West" or the "Nationalized Subject" (Spivak 102). To be recognized by history, the Eram martyrs would've had to look and sound like "civilized" protesters—organized, documented, and ideologically aligned with Western political models. But the reality of Eram was messy, illiterate, and deeply provincial. Since their "Blood Pilgrimage" doesn't serve the post-colonial state's need for a tidy national identity, their trace is allowed to vanish. Since they do not meet the ideal model of revolutionaries, they are erased from history. Ultimately, Eram's omission demonstrates that it is not only a matter of the subaltern being unable to "speak," but that the canon itself rejects the hearing of those who do not resemble it.

CONCLUSION

The vanishing of the Eram Massacre from our mainstream literary canon isn't just a simple historical oversight—it's a deep, structural exclusion. This research shows that when an event as monumental as the 1942 "Blood Pilgrimage" gets treated like a regional footnote, it's the direct result of "epistemic violence" (Spivak 76). It's what happens when elite, English-language narratives are systematically prioritized over subaltern truths. The reliance on the Spivak model makes it clear why the Melana Padhia victims—such as illiterate peasants, fishers, and women such as Pari Bewa—were not able to have their voices heard. They were unable to gain entrance into the "scene of writing," which would have allowed them to become known nationally.

But "un-silencing" Eram is possible if we look toward localized texts and oral histories. Works like Dr. Jagannath Patnaik's *Raktatirtha Eram* aren't just books; they're essential

counter-archives. They do more than just list facts; they restore agency to the subaltern by preserving their specific intentions and their local vows of resistance (Patnaik 28). These texts force the literary canon to expand, demanding that we recognize the "micrological textures of power" existing far outside urban centers. Eram challenges the status quo by proving that resistance is often at its most potent where it's least documented—in the isolated "natural fortresses" of the provincial poor.

Ultimately, while the subaltern might not yet "speak" within the halls of academia, their sacrifice is an indelible part of our history. The Eram Massacre is a permanent stain on the record of colonial violence—a "Blood Pilgrimage" that the selective memory of the elite can't just wash away. In order to give their rightful tribute, what is needed, perhaps, is to revise the history. One must recognize the fact that the fire of the freedom movement was no less burning in the distant land of Odisha than in the urban areas like Delhi or Punjab. The subaltern still stands there, looking for its canon.

Works Cited

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